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NEWSPAPER

7th DEC, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

49th WEEK



USA WEST ASIA POLICY & SAUDI ARABIA

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

7th DECEMBER, 2018

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A relationship under stress

Post-Khashoggi, how long can Saudi Arabia retain leverage over the U.S.?



STANLEY JOHNY

The Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) has reportedly concluded that Mohammed bin Salman, the Saudi Arabian Crown Prince, personally ordered the killing of Jamal Khashoggi. The murder of the Saudi dissident journalist at the Kingdom's Istanbul consulate on October 2 has already triggered a global outrage against MBS, as the Crown Prince is known. But U.S. President Donald Trump seems unfazed by both the findings of his spy agency as well as the mounting global outcry. He called the CIA assessment "very premature", while Secretary of State Mike Pompeo said the U.S.'s "historic commitment" to Saudi Arabia is "absolutely vital to America's security" and its "interests in the Middle East".

Thinking like realists

This is a popular argument in Washington. Realists would say the relationship with Saudi Arabia is so vital for American national interests that the U.S. should overlook certain aspects of Saudi behaviour. The Trump administration repeats this argument to justify its lack of action against Riyadh in the wake of the murder of Khashoggi.

But does Saudi Arabia actually have such leverage over America?

The Saudi-U.S. partnership can be dated back to the 1945 meeting between President Franklin D. Roosevelt and Saudi King Abdulaziz ibn Saud, the founder of modern Saudi Arabia and father of current monarch Salman bin Abdulaziz. In the meeting, held on board the USS Quincy in the Suez Canal, both leaders came to a two-way agreement: the U.S. would support and provide military training for Saudi Arabia, while the Kingdom would provide oil and political backing in return. This alliance made sense for both countries during the Cold War. The Saudis were anxious about communist expansion into the Arab/Islamic world. Half of Yemen fell into the hands of Marxism in 1967, and in 1978 communists took power in Afghanistan. And the U.S. wanted uninterrupted flow of oil for its own economic expansion and the post-war reconstruction of Europe. It also wanted a political ally in West Asia.

But the conditions that laid the foundation of this partnership have changed. The Soviet Union fell apart almost three decades ago. America's dependency on Saudi Arabia for oil has also decreased over the years. True, Saudi Arabia remains a major supplier of oil to the U.S. But it doesn't have the leverage over the American economy as it had in 1973 when Arab countries imposed an embargo.



go on mostly Western nations in protest against their support for Israel during the Yom Kippur War with Egypt. The U.S. is now one of the top three crude producers, along with Russia and Saudi Arabia.

Other arguments in favour of stronger partnership cite the massive Saudi investments in the U.S., both treasury securities and private businesses. But Saudi Arabia acts in its interest, not with the goal of helping the U.S. economy. If it sells its U.S. assets, that would also hurt the Saudi economy badly. After all, from economic diversification at home to security guarantees, Saudi Arabia needs the U.S. more than the other way around, which offers Washington room for strategic manoeuvre.

While the strategic potential of the partnership has been shrinking, the U.S. has come under greater scrutiny, especially in the post-9/11 world, for its support for Saudi Arabia, the Wahhabi kingdom that stands opposed to everything the U.S. preaches on global stages — from democracy and respecting human rights to religious freedom and independent

media. It was this broad context that allowed former U.S. President Barack Obama to take a different approach towards Saudi Arabia. He retained the fundamental elements of the partnership, including trade and economic ties, arms sales and security guarantees, while refusing to act in Syria on the Saudi's behalf and moving further ahead to strike a nuclear deal with Iran. He even asked the Saudis and the Iranians to share West Asia and institute a "Cold Peace" in the region.

Back to square one

But President Trump has reversed this approach and rebuilt the administration's West Asia policy, making Saudi Arabia its centrepiece. The twin objectives of the Trump policy are to ensure Israel's security and roll back Iranian influence. It's this tilt that is now stopping him from moving against the Saudis. The administration has already declared what its Iran policy is. It has already pulled the U.S. out of the Iran nuclear deal. And the Americans need Saudi support in their effort to isolate and weaken Iran, something Israel too has been demanding for years. But this is not a larger national security argument, nor is it a realistic one. When the fundamentals of a partnership get weakened and the region undergoes major changes, how long can the U.S. allow its Iran obsession to dictate its policies towards West Asia?

From the realpolitik point, even if the U.S. wants to limit Iranian influence, Saudi Arabia under MBS is not helping the cause. It lost the Syria war. Its intervention in Yemen drove the Houthis further into Iran's embrace. The Qatar blockade has divided the Arab world (Qatar has now quit OPEC as well). The detention of the Lebanese Prime Minister last year has played Lebanese politics into the hands of Hezbollah, the Iran ally.

Mr. Trump, wary of not disrupting his West Asia policy, may stay the course on Saudi Arabia for now. But the growing criticisms of the partnership on Capitol Hill can't be ignored. The Senate has already voted with a huge majority to move forward legislation to end the U.S. involvement in the Yemen war. Republican Senator Bob Corker accused the White House of "moonlighting as a public relations firm for the Crown Prince". Rand Paul, another Republican Senator, says it's time for America to stand up and tell Saudi Arabia, "enough". These are not isolated moral outbursts; they suggest changing undercurrents. There is a growing realisation in Washington that the Saudi pillar of its West Asia policy is getting weak. Mr. Trump, driven by his own notional obsessions, might overlook it. But future American Presidents can't. They may have to start from where Mr. Obama stopped.

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

The USA West Asia Policy revolves around the sole strategy of weakening Iran than concentrating on the failures of Saudi Arabia. Discuss.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

7th December, 2018

2 A relationship under stress

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2 A relationship under stress

But the conditions that laid the foundation of this partnership have changed. The Soviet Union fell apart almost three decades ago. America's dependency on Saudi Arabia for oil has also decreased over the years. True, Saudi Arabia remains a major supplier of oil to the U.S. But it doesn't have the leverage over the American economy as it had in 1973 when Arab countries imposed an embargo on mostly Western nations in protest against their support for Israel during the Yom Kippur War with Egypt. The U.S. is now one of the top three crude producers, along with Russia and Saudi Arabia.

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While the strategic potential of the partnership has been shrinking, the U.S. has come under greater scrutiny, especially in the post-9/11 world, for its support for Saudi Arabia, the Wahhabi kingdom that stands opposed to everything the U.S. preaches on global stages — from democracy and respecting human rights to religious freedom and independent media. It was this broad context that allowed former U.S. President Barack Obama to take a different approach towards Saudi Arabia. He retained the fundamental elements of the partnership, including trade and economic ties, arms sales and security guarantees, while refusing to act in Syria on the Saudis' behalf and moving further ahead to strike a nuclear deal with Iran. He even asked the Saudis and the Iranians to share West Asia and institute a "Cold Peace" in the region.

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ALASKA
USA

CAN

JAMAL KHASHOGGI ENTERING THE
SAUDI CONSULATE IN TURKEY

North
Pacific
Ocean

UNITED STATES

Gulf of Mexico

Caribbean Sea

VENEZUELA

COLOMBIA

PERU

BOLIVIA

BRAZIL

North
Atlantic
Ocean

ISRAEL

IRAN

SAUDI ARABIA

South
Atlantic
Ocean

ALGERIA

LIBYA

EGYPT

IRAQ

YEMEN

SOMALIA

ETHIOPIA

DR CONGO

KENYA

TANZANIA

ANGOLA

ZAMBIA

NAMIBIA

MOZAMBIQUE

SWAZILAND

LESOTHO

AFRICA



JAMAL KHASHOGGI
Journalist, Saudi Arabia

- CIA concluded that Mohammed bin Salman, the Saudi Arabian Crown Prince, personally ordered the killing of Jamal Khashoggi.
- The murder took place at the Istanbul Consulate.



MOHAMMED BIN SALMAN
Crown Prince, Saudi Arabia



WHAT WAS THE AGREEMENT IN 1940s?



It will support and provide military training for Saudi Arabia

It would provide oil and political backing in return and the alliance made sense for both countries during the Cold War.



FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT
Former President, USA

There is quite contradiction between Saudi Arabia and USA

- Democracy
- Respecting human rights
- Religious freedom
- Independent media.



ABDULAZIZ IBN SAUD
Former King, Saudi Arabia

1950 - 1990 ... IT BENEFITTED BOTH USA & SAUDI ARABIA



- 1 The Saudis were anxious about Communist expansion into the Arab / Muslim World.
- 2 Half of Yemen fell into the hands of Marxists in 1967, and in 1978 Communists took power in Afghanistan.
- 3 US wanted uninterrupted flow of oil for its own economic expansion and the post-war reconstruction of Europe.
- 4 It also wanted a political ally in West Asia.

BUT, WHAT CHANGED AFTER 1990s?



US is now one of the top three crude producers, along with Russia and Saudi Arabia.

- 1 The Soviet Union fell apart in 1991.
- 2 USA's dependency on Saudi Arabia for oil decreased over the years.
- 3 Though Saudi Arabia remains a major supplier of oil to the US, but it doesn't have the leverage over the American economy as it had in 1973, when Arab Countries imposed an embargo on most Western Nations in protest against their support for Israel during the Yom Kippur War with Egypt.

WHAT ABOUT THE INVESTMENTS BY SAUDI ARABIA IN USA?



- 1 There are massive investments in U.S. by Saudi Arabia, both in treasury securities and private businesses.
- 2 Saudi Arabia acts in its interest, not with the goal of helping the U.S. economy.
- 3 From economic diversification right up to security guarantees, Saudi Arabia needs the U.S. more than the other way around.

WHY BARACK OBAMA TOOK DIFFERENT APPROACH ON SAUDI ARABIA?



BARACK OBAMA

- 1 Former US President, Barack Obama took different approach.
- 2 He retained fundamental elements of the partnership, including trade and economic ties, arms sales and security guarantees,
- 3 He refused to act in Syria on the Saudis' behalf and struck nuclear deal with Iran.
- 4 He even asked Saudi Arabia and the Iranians to share West Asia and institute a "Cold Peace" in the region.

But, Donald Trump reversed this approach.

WHAT IS THE POLICY ADOPTED BY DONALD TRUMP?



1 Now, he brought Saudi Arabia to the centre stage.

2 The twin objectives of the Trump Policy are:

- Israel security
- Roll back Iranian influence

3 This tilt is now stopping him from moving against the Saudis.

4 US Administration already pulled out of Iran nuclear deal.

5 USA need Saudi support to isolate and weaken Iran. This is the goal of Israel also.

IS THE USA IGNORING GROUND REALITY?



U.S. wants to limit Iranian influence and in this process it is ignoring the weakness of Saudi Arabia.

- 1 Saudi Arabia lost the Syria war.
- 2 The intervention in Yemen drove the Houthis further into Iran's embrace.
- 3 The Qatar blockade has divided the Arab World, Qatar has now quit OPEC as well.
- 4 The detention of the Lebanese Prime Minister last year played Lebanese politics into the hands of Hezbollah, the Iran's ally.

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